

Hall of the Mountain King (both from Suite No. 1), these delightful compositions rapidly gained popularity and have remained firm favorites with the public.

Grieg used literary sources of a very different kind in his songs. He composed around 170 of these during his career, the majority of which were both inspired and interpreted by his wife, Nina. The most celebrated examples, however, were contained in Grieg's only song cycle, *Haugtussa* (The Mountain Maid, Op. 67). This was based on an epic series of poems by the Symbolist author Arne Garborg, whose work Grieg greatly admired. The composer spent three long years agonizing over exactly how to communicate the essence of this mystical love story, before eventually distilling it into an exquisite cycle of eight songs for female voice and piano. The final work was first performed by Norway's celebrated mezzo-soprano singer Eva Nansen.

By this stage, Grieg's life had settled into a familiar routine. In 1885, he and Nina moved into the house that they had built for themselves at Trolldhaugen, on the shores of the picturesque Bergen fjord. There, Grieg spent the spring and summer working in his "composer's hut" at the water's edge or walking in the mountains, before setting off with Nina in the fall to undertake lengthy concert tours around Europe. These were great social occasions and highly successful with the public, but they were also quite grueling and eventually took their toll on the composer's frail health.

Edvard Grieg died just as he was about to embark on a tour of England. He had, at least, lived long enough to see his beloved Norway gain its independence in 1905. His ashes were buried